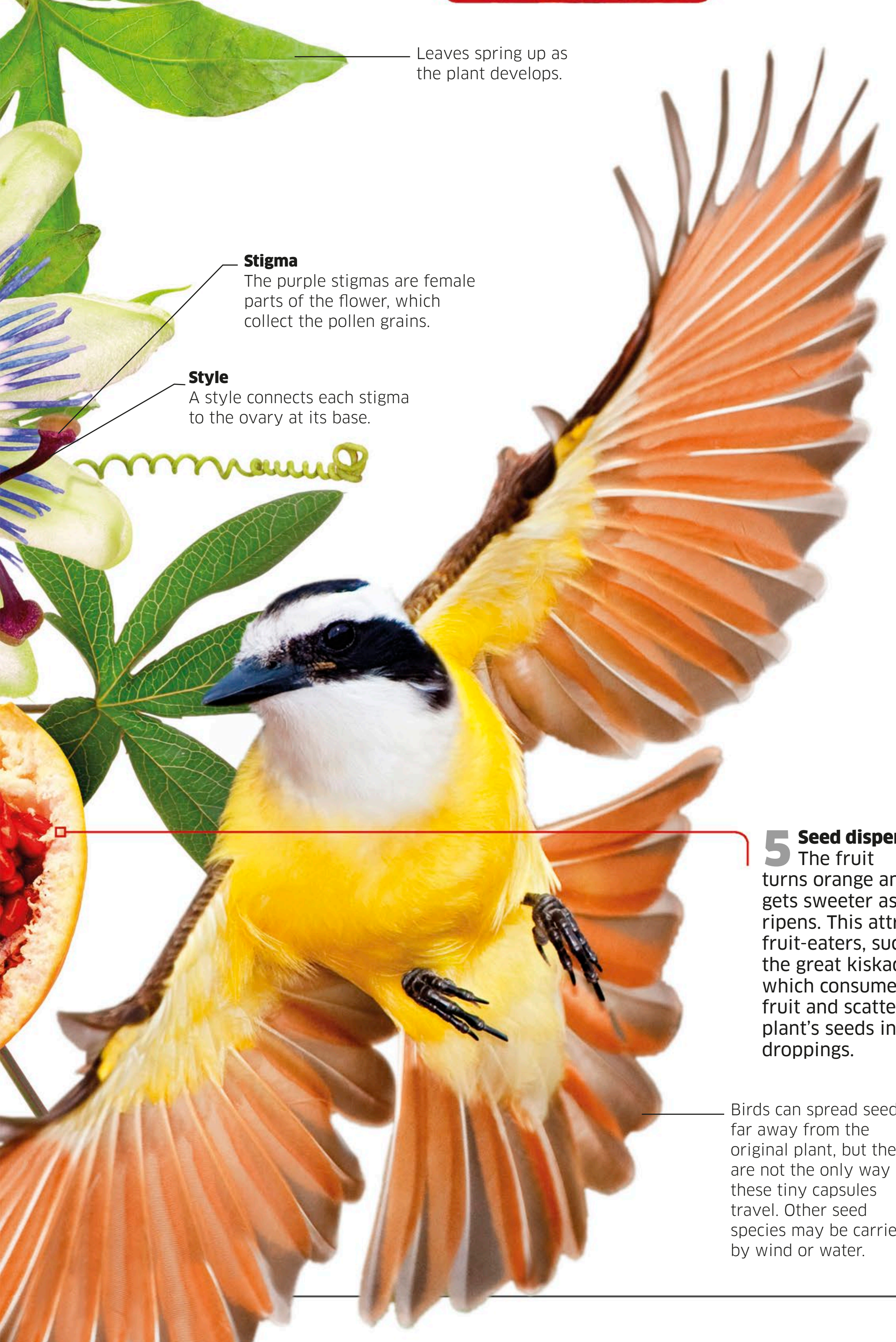

A new shoot emerges from the split seed capsule.

6 Germination If seeds land on moist ground, the embryos inside them start to grow and the seeds germinate. Roots grow down to absorb water and minerals, while shoots sprout upward to make leaves.

Leaves spring up as the plant develops.

Stigma
The purple stigmas are female parts of the flower, which collect the pollen grains.

Style
A style connects each stigma to the ovary at its base.

5 Seed dispersal The fruit turns orange and gets sweeter as it ripens. This attracts fruit-eaters, such as the great kiskadee, which consume the fruit and scatter the plant's seeds in their droppings.

Birds can spread seeds far away from the original plant, but they are not the only way these tiny capsules travel. Other seed species may be carried by wind or water.

Asexual reproduction

Many plants can reproduce asexually–meaning without producing male and female sex cells. Some develop side shoots, or runners, that split away into new plants. A few grow baby plants on their leaves.

Tiny new plants growing on the leaf of a hen-and-chicken fern fall off to produce entirely new ferns.

Reproducing by spores

Mosses and ferns do not produce flowers and seeds, but scatter spores instead. Spores are different from seeds, as they contain just a single cell rather than a fertilized embryo. These cells grow into plants with reproductive organs, which must fertilize each other to develop into mature plants that can produce a new generation of spores.

1 Scattering spores Fully-grown moss shoots release countless single-celled spores from spore capsules. These are carried by the wind, landing where each can grow into a new plant.

2 Sex organs develop Landing on moist ground, the spores grow into tiny, leafy shoots with microscopic sex organs. Male organs produce sperm, and female organs produce eggs.

3 Fertilization Falling raindrops allow swimming sperm cells to reach the eggs held inside the female sex organs, where they fertilize them.

4 Spore capsule grows Each fertilized egg grows into a new spore-producing shoot with a spore capsule, ready to make more spores and repeat the life cycle.